Otto Carlo Hofer, PhD

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PROFILE

Quantitative political scientist (PhD, University of Warwick, pass with no corrections). Research on media, geography, and political attitudes in Europe, combining panel data, causal-inference designs, geospatial analysis, and survey experiments. Currently postdoctoral researcher at Queen Mary University of London on the Horizon Europe DEMETRA project.

CURRENT POSITION

Postdoctoral Research Associate, Queen Mary University of London *May 2024 – Present*

Horizon Europe DEMETRA project on deliberative policy-making · PI: Prof. Maria Grasso

- Coordinate scientific work across 11 institutions and 7 countries against fixed European Commission deadlines; end-to-end ownership of project-wide deliverables, including the two policy briefs I sole-authored from the four work packages' findings, each distributed to 337 policymakers and practitioners at EU, national and local level.
- Drafted the project's ethics plan, data management plan, communication plan, and dissemination & exploitation plan; prepared the periodic project report for the European Commission reviewers.
- Central ethics-approval lead for the consortium: QMUL is the project's host institution, so I run ethics applications across all work packages and liaise with partner institutions on local approvals.
- Field researcher on the qualitative work package: semi-structured interviews and participant observation in deliberative settings.
- Lead organiser of two QMUL-hosted events: the DEMETRA consortium meeting (May 2024) and the Politics and Society Workshop co-sponsored by DEMETRA and the DESPO ERC project (Mar 2026); built and run the project's external presence (website, multi-platform social media, partner video content).

EDUCATION

PhD, Politics and International Studies, University of Warwick *2020 – 2026*

Thesis: Exposure structures and intergroup attitudes in the UK: Linking media infrastructure and residential environments to affective polarisation and immigration attitudes. Open access in WRAP: wrap.warwick.ac.uk/202258/ Viva 31 March 2026; degree conferred 12 May 2026.

Supervisors: Prof. Vincenzo Bove, Dr Andreas Murr. Examiners: Prof. Peter Thisted Dinesen (Copenhagen), Prof. Özlem Atikcan (Warwick). Outcome: pass with no corrections (highest UK outcome).

Two empirical projects on the British Election Study Internet Panel (2015–2020, 100,000+ observations across 11 waves): (i) the link between online information consumption and political affective polarisation, using within-person fixed-effects, an instrumental-variables design exploiting local broadband performance, and Granger-inspired cross-lagged panel models; (ii) the link between neighbourhood ethnic segregation and immigration attitudes, using indices of evenness and exposure computed at the MSOA level (geolocated panel, ~7,200 areas), matched to LTIM migration flows and Townsend deprivation.

MSc, Management, Ca' Foscari University of Venice *2018 – 2020*

110/110 cum laude (highest Italian grade) · GPA 29.5/30 · dissertation (full marks): "Political participation in the age of globalisation: The influence of the Chinese import shock and the Internet on European politics".

BSc, Management & Technology (Computer Science), Technical University of Munich *2014 – 2018*

Bachelor's thesis grade 1.0 (top 1%); monetary prize from AutoScout24 for industry-partnered dissertation.

Visiting research positions

University of Amsterdam (Jun–Aug 2024) · King's College London (Jan–Jun 2024) · EUTOPIA Visiting PhD, University of Gothenburg (Apr–May 2022).

PUBLICATIONS AND RESEARCH OUTPUTS

Refereed journal articles

Sleiman, Y., Grasso, M., Pattie, C., Serra, L., & Hofer, C. (2026). "Polarising punchlines: The influence of intergroup humour on affective political polarisation." *Political Studies*, advance online publication. doi.org/10.1177/00323217261496123

In preparation

Sole-authored. "No larger than television: online political attention and partisan affect in Britain, 2015-2024." PhD project, in preparation.

Sole-authored. "Where migrants live and what their neighbours think: composition, segregation and a decade of measured neighbourhood change in England and Wales." PhD project, in preparation.

Lead author. "Not that funny: a preregistered test of climate memes and political participation." In preparation, from the ESRC humour project.

Co-author. "'OK Boomer': The influence of humour on intergenerational hostility and polarisation." Working paper from the ESRC humour project.

Lead author. "Resilient ridership: the local and short-lived footprint of terrorist attacks on the London Underground." In preparation, from the UK Home Office-advised project (Warwick, 2022).

Policy briefs

Hofer, C. (2026). "Citizens as Partners in Food System Transformation: Scaling Deliberative Democracy for Sustainable Food Systems." DEMETRA Policy Brief No. 1, Horizon Europe DEMETRA project (Grant Agreement No. 101132286). doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22541483

Hofer, C. (2026). "Beyond Pilots: Building Durable Governance Frameworks for Urban Food Systems." DEMETRA Policy Brief No. 2. Based on 120 policymaker interviews across seven European cities. doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22541657

Data deposits

Hofer, C., Serra, L., Sleiman, Y., Grasso, M., & Pattie, C. (2026). *Breaking the Ice: The Impact of Humour on Climate Change Attitudes and Political Participation, 2024*. [Data Collection]. UK Data Service. doi.org/10.5255/UKDA-SN-858416

Grasso, M., Hofer, C., Pattie, C., Serra, L., & Sleiman, Y. (2026). *Political Humour, Political Attitudes and Political Behaviour, 2024*. [Data Collection]. UK Data Service. doi.org/10.5255/UKDA-SN-858418

Serra, L., Sleiman, Y., Hofer, C., Grasso, M., & Pattie, C. (2026). *'Ok Boomer': The Influence of Humour on Intergenerational Hostility and Polarisation, 2024*. [Data Collection]. UK Data Service. doi.org/10.5255/UKDA-SN-858406

Sleiman, Y., Grasso, M., Pattie, C., Serra, L., & Hofer, C. (2026). *Polarising Punchlines: The Influence of Inter-group Humour on Partisan Affective Polarisation, 2024*. [Data Collection]. UK Data Service. doi.org/10.5255/UKDA-SN-858409

Research notes and open data

Hofer, C. (2026). "What a vintage difference measures: hand verification of ownership changes in a public asset-level database." Self-published research note, with code and data released before analysis. github.com/ochofer/paper1-hazard-exposure-data

EARLIER ACADEMIC EXPERIENCE

Research Associate, Queen Mary University of London *Oct 2023 – Apr 2024*

ESRC project "The Impact of Political Humour on Political Attitudes and Behaviours" · PI: Prof. Maria Grasso

- Co-designed one survey and three pre-registered survey experiments on climate communication, intergroup humour, and intergenerational hostility; led ethics applications and roll-out.
- Lead-authored working paper on humorous climate communication; co-authored two further papers (one published in Political Studies).
- Deposited four study datasets, now published with DOIs on the UK Data Service ReShare repository.

Research Associate (UK Home Office advisory), University of Warwick *Jul – Dec 2022*

ESRC project on terrorism and well-being · PI: Prof. Vincenzo Bove

- Estimated the effect of the 2017 London attacks on Underground ridership using daily TfL entry and exit counts (214 stations, 18,369 station-days); briefed Home Office officials on the results.
- Built the project's geospatial layer in Python and the Google Routes API, constructing five proximity measures: straight-line distance, and public-transport and walking duration and distance.
- Found no avoidance of the Underground beyond the mechanical effect of the station closures; the null holds on all five measures, against a design powered to detect a 2.2-4.4% effect four times in five.

Senior Graduate Teaching Assistant, University of Warwick *Sep 2021 – Sep 2023*

- Sole tutor (under the module leader) for Introduction to Quantitative Political Analysis I and II (BSc Politics) in 2021–22, leading all seminars and computer classes.

Research Assistant, Ca' Foscari University of Venice (Banca IFIS engagement) *May – Nov 2019*

- Quantitative screening of 700+ SME financial statements; co-designed and conducted the qualitative interview phase with selected business owners; prepared the analysis and the deck for the PI's final presentation to Banca IFIS senior management.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS AND WORKSHOPS

- "Not that funny: a preregistered test of climate memes and political participation." MPSA Annual Conference, Chicago (2024); PSA Annual Conference, Glasgow (2024); Politics and Society Workshop (DEMETRA & DESPO ERC), QMUL (2026).
- "Media consumption and affective polarisation." SISP General Conference, Genoa (2023); EPOP Annual Conference, Newcastle (2022); ECPR General Conference, Innsbruck (2022); in-house seminars, University of Gothenburg and University of Warwick (2022).
- "Segregation and anti-immigration attitudes." SISP General Conference, Genoa (2023); EPOP Annual Conference, Southampton (2023).
- "Economic and ecological cost of terror in London." UK Home Office internal conference, London (2023).
- Invited project talks: DEMETRA progress and findings presented to sister Horizon Europe consortia - RETOOL project meeting (Feb 2025), RETOOL synthesis workshop (Jun 2025), and CO-SUSTAIN stakeholder webinar (Mar 2026).
- DEMETRA project meetings: QMUL (May 2024, organiser), online (Oct 2024), Uppsala University (Apr 2025), online (Oct 2025), University of Lille (Apr 2026).
- ECPR Summer School "Quasi-experimental Methods for Causal Inference" with Elias Dinas (2020).

ACADEMIC SERVICE AND ORGANISING

- Lead organiser: DEMETRA consortium meeting, QMUL (May 2024); Politics and Society Workshop co-sponsored by DEMETRA and the DESPO ERC project, QMUL (Mar 2026).

- Organising committee and chair, international conference "Terrorism, Public Attitudes and Individual Well-being," University of Warwick (2022).
- Co-founder and co-chair, Quantitative Solutions & Networking Series, University of Warwick (2022); co-chair, CRIPS graduate working group, Warwick (2020–21).

FUNDING AND AWARDS

- PhD scholarship (full fees + living stipend), University of Warwick (2020–2024).
- EUTOPIA Visiting PhD scholarship (€5,000), University of Gothenburg (2022).
- Doctoral College Fund, University of Warwick.
- Research assistant scholarship, Ca' Foscari University of Venice (2019).
- AutoScout24 monetary prize (€1,000) for BSc dissertation with full marks (top 1%), 2018.

METHODS, TOOLS, AND LANGUAGES

Quantitative methods: panel-data analysis · within-person fixed-effects · cross-lagged / dynamic panel models · instrumental variables · survey design and pre-registered survey experiments · geospatial analysis (100m–MSOA scales) · segregation indices (dissimilarity, Theil's H, isolation).

Qualitative methods: semi-structured interviewing · participant observation · field research.

Tools: R · Stata · Python · SQL · Google Routes API · LaTeX · Git · Markdown.

Languages: Italian (native) · German (native) · English (C2) · Dutch (C1, conversational and capable of teaching) · Spanish (B2) · French (B1) · Mandarin (A2).